the main catalyst for ISRO striking a deal with SEP in 1974 to develop the Vikas engine. Viking, Vikas's French counterpart, continues to fire the famous Ariane rockets. Grover would also go on to be famous in India as the man behind Grover Vineyards that brought quality wine to India at an affordable price.

On that night at Le Lido, Grover happened to sit near me. We started talking about the French weather, and were soon engrossed in a conversation about rocketry and India's struggle to develop rocket engines that could be used for satellite launches. I learned that Grover was an agent for HMT milling machines. France wanted many such machines; HMT in India was making them, but was not adept at selling them abroad. Grover, with his impeccable communication and networking skills, made a roaring business out of the opportunity. He was also trying to be an SEP agent, which he became before striking the Indo-French deal.

With Souffle and Morin being friendly, and a good push at the right time by Grover, the French allowed me to visit many of their propulsion facilities, including a missile-making centre. Later I had wondered why they let me in there—to impress me with their technology that they were keen on selling or the belief that an Indian scientist wouldn't be able to take away anything from a cursory visit of a missile-making facility? The missile facility, however, remained out of bounds for foreign scientists soon after my visit, and I was probably the only one from ISRO to have had a ringside view of the early French missiles. The French were not foolish by letting me in, though. One cannot develop a rocket by seeing how it is made, not even if given detailed drawings of all the systems. If that was the case, a small-scale industrialist doing a metal plating for a rocket part should be able to replicate the rocket since he, like any other contractor, is given the blueprint. Lack of this basic understanding was to make many believe in the ISRO spy case of the mid-1990s, as the Indian Intelligence Bureau concocted the story of us selling the Vikas engine and cryogenic engine secrets to Pakistan through two ill-educated Maldivian women.

A rocket cannot be made with just the know-how. You need the 'know-why'. And, for that, you need to work with the masters for years, be part of